

or whatever they need. That is a big show of talent. A lot of ideas that go into these hackathons actually come from open source, where people find some tool or some piece of software and build a prototype that shows how that software can be leveraged to make our products.

In India, we don't do a 24-hour event, but what we do is tell people to work on something that they find worthy of their time. We term it as Pega Innovations, where we evaluate the projects that people work on and we award them too. We use that piece of innovation in our product as well, if the need be. We do similar such events in other parts of the world at different Pega facilities as well.

Q Do you see enough drive in the Indian engineers to contribute to open source technology compared to what you see in the US?

I think so. Actually, it varies from person to person rather than being determined by geographies. There are some people who are really passionate about contributing code to a project, while there are others who take it a bit casually. The engineers who have a passion for engineering look for every opportunity to get involved in something that is innovative and interesting. You can find such engineers everywhere. Our Amsterdam team is probably more active than any other team in contributing to open source projects, but we have a good population of people in India as well, who are actively participating in open source projects.

Q Do you think that the demand for engineers with open source technology skills is increasing over a period of time because of more widespread adoption?

Frankly, this is not something that I have given much thought to. We don't actively ask people about their experiences in open source technology. It is not one of the criteria that we consider. When we hire at Pega, we hire for aptitude and commitment. We like to take energetic people on board who love what they do. If we are able to find such people, they can always learn the technologies we work on. My guess though, is that the open source community has come out of being seen as weird. For a while, I think everybody thought that it was a bit strange, but we have a lot of customers who run their operations on Linux. For instance, Postgres is now becoming a very popular database. We did support Postgres in the last two years, as we thought it was something that would become really important. Mainstream corporations are now adopting these technologies, whereas 10 years ago, I think everyone was very sceptical. And this has opened more doors for people contributing to open source technologies.

Q Are your customers open to adopting solutions based on open source technology?

I have seen a huge change in the mindset of my customers for open source technology over a period of time. Linux is

now respectable, though it wasn't so earlier. A lot of our customers run JBoss with TomCat and they have a lot of interest in Postgres.

Q How do FOSS tools add value to the development process?

Tools help you get things done faster and better. And with open source components, you don't have to build stuff. You can leverage other people's expertise and focus on more important areas. It also improves the pace of development.

Q If I am a developer who wishes to be hired at Pega, on what basis would I be evaluated?

Everyone has to undergo a set process. As I said, we will first test your aptitude. We also run Open Days. People hear about it and come in. These Open Days are like walk-in interviews and we have them on most weekends. People come in and we show them a video of who we are, what we do, what our vision is and what our technology does, so that they have some understanding. Then we ask them to take a standard online test. Some part of the test comprises just technology questions, about databases, Java, Java Script, HTML, CSS and some of the other basic technologies.

A lot of the questions involve problem solving, where we look for people's aptitude. Here we test how the candidates think and whether they can think the way we do. It is not about how many correct answers you have given, but it is about the type of questions people dwell on. It tells us about the potential cultural fit and also the areas in Pega where they can fit in well, because we have different requirements for different disciplines. We then pick some people that we are interested in, and they have to undergo some personal interviews for the final recruitment. The interviews are conducted by two to three people from the engineering team, who ask candidates to explain things that they have worked on, ask them some 'what if' type questions and enquire about their interests. This tells us whether they will fit into the culture of the company or not, and then we make the decision.

Q Do you think certifications help in getting a job, particularly in a company like Pega?

Yes. If a candidate has certifications in any of the technologies that we use a lot, they are a great indication that somebody really does have the knowledge of the subject. As a company, we really promote certifications. So, all of the partner staff get certifications in Pega technologies like Certified System Architect, Certified Senior System Architect, Certified Lead System Architect, all of which are progressively advanced qualifications. We tell our customers that when they are hiring staff, they should look for certifications. This is something we very much believe in as a cultural thing at Pega. 